

AZURE DEVOPS · PROJECT SETTINGS

Team & Project Configuration

Configuring Teams, Iterations, and Areas in Project Settings
— with real-world examples.

A practical guide for DevOps administrators



What this guide covers

01

The building blocks

How organizations, projects, teams, areas, and iterations fit together

02

Teams configuration

Creating teams, members, administrators, and the tools each team gets

03

Area paths

Organizing work by product, component, or feature — and assigning to teams

04

Iteration paths

Defining sprints and release cadences, then sharing them across teams

05

Team configuration

Mapping areas, iterations, default sprints, and working days per team

06

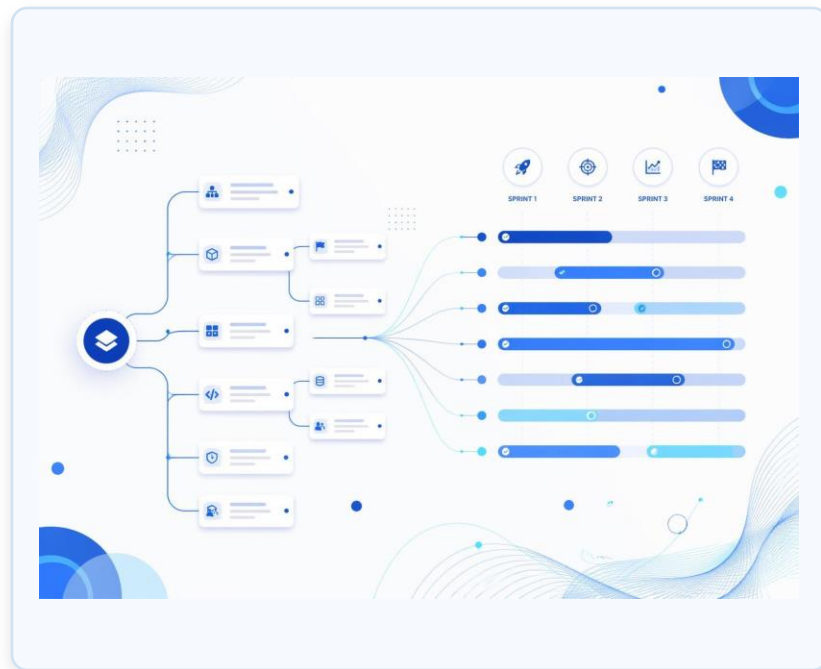
Real-world setup & best practices

A multi-team project example, common pitfalls, and golden rules

One project, many organized views

Azure DevOps gives every project a single, shared pool of work items. Teams, area paths, and iteration paths are the three levers that turn that pool into focused, manageable views.

- **Organization → Project** The outer structure that holds all boards, repos, and pipelines.
- **Teams** Configurable views — each gets its own backlog, board, sprint, and dashboard.
- **Area paths** What a work item belongs to (product, component, or feature).
- **Iteration paths** When the work is scheduled — sprints, releases, and milestones.



Teams, area paths, and iteration paths

Teams

A filtered view, not an owner

- Each team gets a backlog, board, sprint view & dashboard
- A team filters the shared work pool — it never owns items
- Created in Project Settings → Teams

Area Paths

What the work belongs to

- Hierarchical labels for product, component or feature
- Only matching items show on a team's backlog & board
- Up to 14 levels deep; 10,000 per project

Iteration Paths

When the work happens

- Time-boxed sprints, releases or program increments
- Defined once at project level, shared across teams
- Each team selects which sprints are active

Where configuration lives in Project Settings

Three places in Project Settings control how work is organized. Project-level admins define structure; team admins tailor each team's view.

1 Teams

Project Settings → Teams

Create teams, add members & administrators, set the default team.

2 Project Configuration

Project Settings → Boards → Project Configuration

Define area paths and iteration paths (sprints) for the whole project.

3 Team Configuration

Project Settings → Team Configuration

Assign areas & iterations to a team; set defaults and working days.

Creating and configuring teams

Project Settings → Teams → New team

1

Name the team

Each new project ships with a default team named after the project.

2

Add members & an administrator

Team admins can configure backlogs, boards, and capacity.

3

Create its area path

Tick “Create an area path with the team name,” or assign one later.

4

Tune the team's tools

Backlog levels, working days, and boards are all per-team.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

Project “Fabrikam”

As the product grows, one default team splits into four focused teams sharing a single project:



Frontend



Backend



Platform



QA / Release

Organize work by product and component

Example hierarchy

Fabrikam

Frontend

Dashboard · Settings · Auth

Backend

API · Workers · Database

Platform

Infrastructure · CI-CD · Monitoring

How teams use them

Assign, then filter — A team sees only the work items whose area path it owns.

One item, one board — Golden rule: each work item should appear on exactly one team's board.

Avoid overlap — Sharing an area path across teams causes silent board-column conflicts.

Mind the limits — Up to 14 levels deep, 10,000 per project, and 300 per team.

Define sprints and release cadences

Example sprint structure

Fabrikam \ 2026-Q1

Sprint 1 Jan 5 – Jan 16

Sprint 2 Jan 19 – Jan 30

Sprint 3 Feb 2 – Feb 13

Sprint 4 Feb 16 – Feb 27

Sprint 5 Mar 2 – Mar 13

Shared, but flexible

 **Defined once** — Iteration paths live at the project level and are shared by all teams.

 **Teams opt in** — Each team picks which sprints are active in its own view.

 **Set the dates** — Sprints have no dates by default — add them to enable burndown & velocity.

 **Mixed cadences** — Two-week sprints are common, but teams can run different schedules.

Map areas, iterations, and capacity to a team

Project Settings → Team Configuration. Once project admins define the structure, team admins tailor each team's view.

Areas

- Pick the team's default area path
- Add extra area paths for shared work
- Choose whether sub-areas roll up

Iterations

- Select which sprints the team uses
- Set the default & current iteration
- Pick a backlog iteration for new items

Capacity & days

- Define working days for the schedule
- Set per-member capacity each sprint
- Default is 6 productive hours per day

Real-world setup: one project, four teams

A single “Fabrikam” project supports four teams. Area paths split the work; the shared Q1 sprints keep everyone on one cadence.

Team	Default area path	Iterations	Focus
Frontend	Fabrikam \ Frontend	Q1 \ Sprint 1–6	Dashboard, settings, auth UI
Backend	Fabrikam \ Backend	Q1 \ Sprint 1–6	APIs, workers, data services
Platform	Fabrikam \ Platform	Q1 \ Sprint 1–6	Infra, CI/CD, monitoring
QA / Release	Fabrikam (all sub-areas)	Shared view	Cross-team quality & releases

Golden rule: each work item lives under exactly one team's area path, so it appears on exactly one board.

Best practices and common pitfalls

Do this

- ✓ Start with one project; scale with teams, areas, and iterations.
- ✓ Add at least one area path per team you create.
- ✓ Keep each work item on exactly one team's board.
- ✓ Set sprint dates so burndown and velocity charts work.

Avoid this

- ✗ Overlapping area paths across teams — they cause board-column conflicts.
- ✗ Deleting areas or iterations in use — it permanently loses chart history.
- ✗ Spinning up extra projects when teams and areas would do the job.
- ✗ Leaving the default team to hold everything as you scale.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Structure once, focus everywhere

Teams are views

Each team filters the shared work pool — it never owns the items.

Areas answer “what”

Hierarchical paths route work to exactly one team's board.

Iterations answer “when”

Project-level sprints, shared and opted into per team.

Configure deliberately

Set defaults, dates, and working days; avoid overlap and deletions.